

Undergraduate Research Scholarship Project Proposal

Understanding Advantaged Identity Management Strategies and Definitions of Privilege

Introduction:

Social inequality has suffused society, allowing access to advantages and opportunities only to members of certain social groups, while disadvantaging others. This disproportionately high access, or privilege, dictates opportunities, resources, and everyday experiences, but frequently goes unnoticed by its beneficiaries (McIntosh, 1988; Phillips & Lowery, 2018; 2020; Wu & Dunning, 2020). Privilege has played an important role in inequality discourse, but psychological research has only recently begun to examine how individuals understand and interpret it. New findings suggest that people differ substantially in how they define and recognize privilege and its implications.

Lay Beliefs of Privilege

Recent research suggests that individuals vary systematically in their definitions of privilege. The literature has identified six common definitions and related them to social outcomes, including recognition of group-based advantage, support for equality-enhancing policies, and engagement in allyship. Defining privilege as “controllable” (earned) impedes recognition and equality-enhancing efforts, whereas defining privilege as “structural” (institutional or systemic) and “pervasive” (affecting many areas of society and applies to all members of a group) is associated with greater recognition and support for equality-enhancing efforts (e.g., policy reform and allyship action). Defining privilege as “invisible” (people with privilege are unaware they have it) is particularly endorsed; however, it is associated with more uncertainty about methods for inequality reduction (Brown et al., 2026). While it is important to

understand the consequences of these definitions, what leads people to adopt these distinct definitions of privilege is still an open question.

Advantaged Identity Management and Privilege Definitions

Much privilege research details how advantaged group members manage their identities when confronted with inequality, and these identity strategies may help explain why certain privilege definitions are endorsed. Research on motivated reasoning, system justification, and planned behavior suggests that individuals' beliefs are often aligned with identity-relevant motives (Ajzen, 1991; Jost and Banaji, 1994; Kunda, 1990). Drawing from social identity theory, which posits that individuals are motivated to maintain a positive social identity and protect the value of their group membership when it is threatened (Tajfel and Turner, 1979), advantaged group members (e.g., men in the United States) may experience moral or status threats when privilege (e.g., male privilege) becomes salient and, in response, adopt psychological strategies to regulate that discomfort. Because advantaged group members are motivated to view themselves as fair and moral and to preserve social hierarchies (Phillips et al., 2018), confronting evidence of privilege can threaten both self-concept and group legitimacy, affecting how these individuals manage being confronted with this identity.

Recent research identifies four strategies used to manage these privileged identity threats: (1) justifying or reframing privilege as legitimate and deserved (Defend), (2) rejecting the existence of inequality or privilege (Deny), (3) psychologically distancing from the advantaged group (Distance), or (4) supporting inequality reduction (Dismantle) (Knowles et al., 2014; Shuman et al., 2025). We propose that those who engage in certain strategies to dispel identity-related threats may also choose privilege definitions that align with those strategies. For example, individuals motivated to maintain the legitimacy of existing hierarchies (status

motives) may adopt defending or denying strategies (Shuman et al., 2025), and may also choose to define privilege as controllable or merit-based because defining privilege as controllable (i.e., earned) allows people to perceive their privilege was deserved and worked for. Additionally, when seeking to maintain moral innocence, people often engage in the distancing identity strategy. Those who engage in the distance strategy may choose to define privilege as invisible since perceiving privilege as something people are unconscious and unaware of might allow them to dispel personal responsibility. Past work on bias shows that describing bias as implicit or unconscious (perhaps invisible), as opposed to explicit or within awareness, reduces responsibility attribution (towards biased agents) and desire for punishment (Daumeyer et al., 2019; 2021). In contrast, dismantling reflects a focus on systemic inequality, which may therefore align with defining privilege as structural and pervasive since these definitions emphasize institutional patterns which require collective action and change. Taken together, identity management strategies and privilege definitions may be linked through shared underlying motivations.

Research Question

The present study examines the relationship between advantaged identity management strategies and lay beliefs of privilege within the contexts of race and gender; specifically, two studies will investigate whether individuals who engage in defending, denying, distancing, or dismantling strategies differ in their definitions of privilege along the dimensions of controllability, structural perceptions, pervasiveness, and invisibility. These studies also explore whether ideological beliefs (e.g. social dominance orientation, meritocratic beliefs) are related to identity management strategies and privilege definitions. These studies are correlational, but the findings should provide a foundation for future causal research.

Hypotheses and Expected Outcomes

(H1) Higher levels of defending or denying strategies will be associated with defining privilege as controllable (or earned on an individual level), and negatively associated with defining privilege as structural or pervasive. These strategies protect the legitimacy of the existing social hierarchies and reduce perceived responsibility for inequality (Knowles et al., 2014; Shuman et al., 2025).

(H2) Higher levels of distancing strategies will be associated with defining privilege as existing but less personally relevant, emphasizing the invisibility of privilege. Distancing allows people to acknowledge the existence of privilege while psychologically separating themselves from their advantaged group membership in some way (Knowles et al., 2014).

(H3) Higher levels of dismantling strategies will be associated with defining privilege as structural and pervasive, and negatively associated with defining it as controllable or earned. Dismantling strategies echo a motivation to confront, denounce, and reduce systemic inequality (Shuman et al., 2025).

Methodology

These studies are cross-sectional correlational. Participants will be recruited via Ohio State's REP and through online platforms (i.e., Prolific Academic), and we will specifically recruit White Americans in Study 1 and those who identify as men in Study 2. Participants will complete an online survey assessing their identity management strategies, lay beliefs of privilege, and other relevant demographic variables. The management strategies will be measured using the Defend, Deny, Distance, and Dismantle scale, and the lay beliefs will be assessed using the multidimensional scale from Brown et al. (2026) with the six common

dimensions of privilege. Additional measures such as social dominance orientation and meritocratic beliefs will be included to explore relationships with other ideological influences.

Data will be analyzed using multiple regression and correlational analyses to examine associations between identity management strategies and privilege beliefs. Exploratory analyses may test whether ideological or demographic variables also account for any shared variance.

This project is designed to be completed within one year (potentially including future related studies based on the initial findings), and no specialized equipment is required besides survey software (e.g. Qualtrics) and statistical tools (e.g. R, SPSS).

Personal Statement

As a dual major in Psychology and Statistics, I have completed classes in social psychology and statistical methods (including regression and correlations). I have also become acquainted with literature on psychological phenomena like inequality and identity processes through my work as a research assistant in two psychology labs. I hope to be able to continue to do research and contribute to scientific literature by going to graduate school and continuing my career in academia. This project will be conducted under the supervision of Dr. Riana Brown, a social psychologist who specializes in inequality and social action research. This is an independent honors thesis project that builds on Dr. Brown's past research on privilege to understand how and why different definitions of privilege are endorsed.

Citations

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